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on the topic:

«One Belt, One Road»: Evolution, Challenges and Prospects for International Cooperation

Author:
4th-year student
full-time programme
Narmandakh Namuundelger__
Signature _____

Academic supervisor:
Doctor of Sciences (Dr. Sc.), Professor
Alexander Ivanovich Sukharev
Grade_____
Signature _____

«Admitted to defence»

Head of the Chair of «International Cooperation»

Doctor of Sciences (Dr. Sc.), Prof. S. A. Semedov

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Introduction

Energy resources are becoming scarce, consumption is growing at unsustainable rates, global financial and economic crises are becoming more frequent and prolonged, and overproduction is creating a surplus of goods, which has led to falling prices for major raw materials on the world market. At a time when the global political climate has cooled owing to disagreements among the leading world powers over the settlement of the crises in Ukraine and Syria, the Chinese leadership has launched the global «One Belt, One Road» concept and, as a global power, is building the «Silk Road» economic zone across Eurasia. Researchers believe that this joint initiative with other countries will make an important contribution to strengthening cooperation between countries around the world. As a result, 65 countries around China have expressed interest in participating in the «Silk Road» project, which is to be implemented within the framework of the «One Belt, One Road» concept. Since the launch of the initiative, China's political, social, economic and cultural influence in the region has increased. China continues to invest heavily in the development of international transport and logistics infrastructure, relocating domestic production abroad and investing in the energy and mining sectors. Many researchers have described these investments as «fictitious». Another group of researchers emphasises that the implementation of «One Belt, One Road» depends on cooperation between countries, or that China lacks a developed policy framework. For this reason, the present study was undertaken to analyse the problems facing China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative.

Object of the study

The object of the study is the «One Belt, One Road» initiative.

Subject of the study

The subject of the study is the economic, political and social aspects of the initiative that affect international cooperation.

Aim of the study

The main aim of this study is to analyse the evolution of the «One Belt, One Road» initiative, to assess the challenges and prospects for international cooperation, and to identify the factors that contribute to the effective development of the initiative.

Objectives of the study

The objectives of this study are:

- to analyse and assess the external and internal challenges facing China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative;
- to examine the essence of China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative and the current status of its implementation;
- to identify the needs and requirements for implementing Mongolia's «Steppe Road» project within the construction of the China–Mongolia–Russia economic corridor.

Methodological basis of the study

This study uses a comprehensive approach that combines theoretical analysis with empirical data. Its theoretical basis draws on concepts of international cooperation, economic integration and geopolitics. Analytical and comparative methods are used to test the hypothesis, making it possible to assess the dynamics of the «One Belt, One Road» initiative and its impact on international relations.

Research methods

The study uses inductive and deductive document analysis, primary and secondary data analysis, analysis and synthesis, and generalisation. A SWOT analysis (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats) is used to compare and summarise the initiative's strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. A PEST analysis is also used to identify and compare the influence of political, economic, social and technological factors in the external environment.

Sources

The study draws on an extensive review of the literature, including academic articles, books and official documents related to the «One Belt, One Road» initiative, with particular attention to the work of leading experts in international relations and economics. The topic is highly relevant in the context of current global economic and political processes. Despite existing research, gaps remain in the understanding of the long-term prospects and challenges of the initiative, particularly with regard to international cooperation. This thesis aims to address these gaps and to provide a deeper analysis of the initiative's evolution.

Relevance of the research topic

By identifying the problems facing China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative, the study proposes ways to address them. It is also intended to serve as a reliable secondary source for researchers from the 65 countries participating in the initiative and for Mongolian researchers who will continue to study this topic.

Research hypothesis

Hypothesis: «The One Belt, One Road initiative will strengthen international cooperation and economic integration in the region, despite existing geopolitical challenges, provided that participating countries ensure effective governance and coordination.»

Structure of the thesis

The thesis consists of six parts: an introduction, three main chapters (the theoretical basis of the research, the current state of the initiative and an analytical section), a conclusion and a list of references.

Chapter 1. Theoretical Foundations of the «One Belt, One Road» Project

1.1 Evolution of the «One Belt, One Road» Concept

The term «Silk Road» was first used by the well-known German geographer Ferdinand von Richthofen (1833–1905) in his work on China in 1877. According to the Encyclopaedia Britannica, «...from about 100 BC, camel caravans travelled a route some 6,400 km long, starting at Chang'an, passing through China along the Great Wall, heading north-west to the Pamir Mountains, crossing Afghanistan and reaching the eastern shore of the Mediterranean, where goods were loaded onto ships and carried to Rome. The route was used to carry silk to the West and wool, gold and silver to the East. With the fall of Ancient Rome it became increasingly dangerous. It was reopened in the Mongol period, and Marco Polo travelled along it in the 13th century.» «Silk Road» is the name commonly given to the great road connecting Asia and Europe, which has been in use for more than 2,000 years. Although it disappeared and re-emerged at various points in history, its importance grew during the rise of the Mongols, when it became a major artery linking West and East, and it is considered to have played an important role in world development. The Silk Road began in Chang'an, the capital of the ancient Han dynasty, and branched in two directions, north and south, leaving China through Gansu province and Xinjiang and

continuing through Central Asia to India, Arabia, Persia and Turkey. The restoration of this historically important road network is being carried out on China's initiative. The road will allow China to expand trade with Europe considerably, while the countries along the route will also benefit, which has attracted strong interest from Central Asian countries and is now gaining momentum. From 1978 to 2010, the average annual growth rate of Chinese government investment in road and transport infrastructure was 17.3 percent. Between 1999 and 2009, under the national «Go West» programme, investment in building and improving transport infrastructure in the western region increased. As a result of the Chinese government's close attention, infrastructure development in the western region improved, and by 2010 it exceeded the national average of infrastructure investment by 9.1 percent. From 1978 to 2010, investment in regional economic infrastructure increased 703.5-fold, and investment in the regional transport sector increased 698-fold. Over the same period, investment in national infrastructure increased 555-fold and investment in national transport 409-fold. Since 2005, «private investment in the transport and infrastructure sectors of the Western region has grown rapidly». The Chinese government regards the development of science and technology education as a fundamental precondition for accelerating infrastructure construction and achieving structural transformation in the construction and industrial sectors, in line with the sustainable development strategy associated with the «One Belt, One Road» initiative. Infrastructure investment funds of the Western region will be consolidated, and their assets will be invested in the private sector, livestock farming, fisheries, mining, construction, wholesale and retail trade, catering, finance, insurance, non-renewable energy, leasing and business support services. In September 2013, during President Xi Jinping's first visit to Central Asia, the innovative «Silk Road» cooperation model was presented as a modern version of the ancient Silk Road and a «Silk Road Economic Belt» across Eurasia. The proposal attracted worldwide attention. In his speech at Nazarbayev University in Kazakhstan, he said: «In order to bring the economies of Eurasian countries closer, deepen mutual cooperation and further expand the space for development, we are

creating an entirely new model of cooperation. We can build it together. This is a great undertaking for the well-being of the people along the road.» He proposed the creation of a «Silk Road Economic Belt» aimed at developing cooperation for the benefit of the peoples of East Asia, Europe, West Asia and Central Asia. China is located between the Indian and Pacific Oceans and between East and Central Asia, and will serve not only as a «land bridge to Eurasia» but also as a link between Asian countries. Although the former Soviet Central Asian states through which the «New Silk Road» passes lack the financial resources to build roads, China is prepared to begin construction with its own funds. China divides the future «New Silk Road» into five sub-regions based on natural, geographical and economic zones. The first is Central Asia, comprising five countries: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan. The second includes Iran, Iraq, Jordan, Syria, Saudi Arabia, Turkey and other countries. These oil- and gas-producing, export-oriented countries have relatively developed energy and power sectors, but they seek to develop cooperation with China in other areas, such as agriculture. The third comprises the Caucasus (Azerbaijan, Georgia, Armenia) and Eastern Europe (Ukraine, Belarus, Moldova and others). These countries are expected, together with East and West, gradually to achieve economic integration with the European Union and thus become a geographical transmission line for Eurasia. The fourth is the Russian Federation. Russia is an important part of the «Silk Road» countries and an independent state at the centre of the region. It is closely connected with Central Asia, the Caucasus and West Asia and has particular political and economic influence. The fifth comprises Afghanistan, Pakistan and India. It is believed that if economic cooperation among these three countries is accelerated, relations among them, as well as the Afghan question, could be resolved in the future. On 3 October 2013, in his speech to the Indonesian parliament, President Xi Jinping stated: «Southeast Asia has since ancient times been an important hub of the Maritime Silk Road, and China has always been a key partner of ASEAN. We hope to strengthen maritime cooperation with ASEAN countries, make full use of the China–ASEAN Maritime Cooperation Fund established by the Chinese government, develop

maritime partnership and jointly build the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road.» China is ready to expand practical cooperation with ASEAN countries in all areas, complement each other's strengths, share risks and achieve common prosperity, and has put forward the concept of the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road. These two main concepts, the «Silk Road Economic Belt» and the «21st Century Maritime Silk Road», were thus combined and are today formulated as «One Belt, One Road». China presents the initiative as a project aimed at strengthening connectivity and the development of all participating countries, rather than as an instrument for increasing Chinese power. As a basis for a more stable and predictable international system, Beijing proposes the creation of a «community of common destiny for mankind», founded on mutual respect, equality, mutually beneficial cooperation, an open and inclusive world economy, fairer and more rational global governance, and multipolarity. At the same time, China does not propose a fundamental revision of the world system: the world would still be divided into «great powers» and all other states, with the difference that a world system led by a great power «of a new type» would be fairer and more predictable. The «One Belt, One Road» project covers an area inhabited by 65 countries and 4.4 billion people, producing 63 percent of world GDP. Building «One Belt, One Road» is a key long-term strategic development goal, described as a «comprehensive alliance» between China and other countries that is «mutually beneficial and win-win», a «comprehensive alliance of common interests» and a «comprehensive community of common destiny» aimed at «joint development and rise». With the implementation of this major project, the countries of «One Belt, One Road» are expected to account for one third of world exports over the next ten years and to become the «third-largest economy in the world», and it is believed that the area will become the «largest pole» of the world economy. The initiative is understood as an idea of mutually beneficial cooperation based on the principles of joint consultation, joint construction and shared benefits, covering West, Central, East and Southeast Asia, Europe, East Africa and the Americas, where countries share their strengths and weaknesses and work together to develop their advantages. Countries such as Tajikistan

and Kyrgyzstan have acquired numerous mineral deposits, and restoring the «Silk Road» network will make it possible to transport minerals from these deposits for processing and then export them to European countries. It has also been stated that «scientific innovation will play a key role in the transition from Made in China to Created in China». In January 2014, at the opening ceremony of the Winter Olympic Games in Sochi, the heads of state of China and Russia met again and held a positive and in-depth discussion on building the Silk Road Economic Belt. Several projects discussed between China and Russia, such as oil and gas pipelines, the Chongqing–Europe railway, the Western China–Western Europe highway and China's interest in the development of the Russian Far East and Siberia, form part of the Silk Road Economic Belt. Researchers believe that the project, combined with regional development, will become a new driver for the comprehensive strategic partnership between China and Russia, in line with the common interests of both countries. The European Union declared 2015 the «Year of China–Europe Partnership» to mark the 40th anniversary of diplomatic relations between China and the European Economic Community (now the European Union), opening the way for EU participation in the «One Belt, One Road» initiative and emphasising that such participation would be important for the further development of bilateral relations in all areas. In 2014, trade between China and Europe reached USD 615 billion. China is prepared to follow the principle of joint use and joint construction with Europe and will strengthen policy coordination, infrastructure connectivity, trade and investment cooperation and people-to-people ties in order to promote common development and prosperity. China and Europe should advance investment negotiations, quickly reach agreements on facilitating the movement of people and promote infrastructure construction. The project will expand cooperation in construction, science and innovation, information and communications, urbanisation, banking and finance, and raise the quality and level of cooperation. The European Union has advantages such as rich technological and scientific resources, which provide the material basis and conditions for its participation in «One Belt, One Road». The project can therefore be implemented in coordination with the European Union's

development programme on a mutually beneficial basis. By the end of May 2015, Chinese investment under the initiative in 64 countries and regions had reached USD 161.2 billion, or 20 percent of China's total outward direct investment. Total trade between China and the countries along the Belt and Road reached USD 400 billion. As of May 2015, direct investment by Chinese companies in 48 countries along the Belt and Road totalled USD 4.86 billion, 3.7 percent more than in the same period of 2014. These countries include Singapore, Indonesia, Laos and Russia. Trade and economic relations between China and the countries along the Belt and Road have deepened. As Chinese companies increase their investment in countries and regions along the initiative, the volume of capital they invest in Europe is also rising rapidly. China is discussing coordination with the European Union on a strategic investment plan worth EUR 315 billion. In its diplomatic activity in recent years, the Chinese government has therefore attached great importance to building «One Belt, One Road», has encouraged countries along the route to participate in order to expand its overseas markets, and has provided them with financial assistance. As construction accelerates, more countries are seeking assistance. China's practical aid policy aims to implement major strategic projects within the «One Belt, One Road» vision and focuses on building roads and railways in neighbouring countries, as well as energy, transport lines, telecommunications, infrastructure and services.[12345]

1 Daniel C. Waugh “Richtofen’s “Silk Road”: Toward the Archeology of a Concept, The Silk Road, Volume 5, number 1, Summer 2007, стр. 1-10

2 Энциклопедия «Шелковый путь» Британника 6, Энциклопедия Британника, Непко, 2011, стр. 313

3 Van Noort, C., & Colley, T. (2021). How do strategic narratives shape policy adoption? Responses to China's Belt and Road Initiative. Review of International Studies, 47(1), 39-63. doi:10.1017/S0260210520000388

4 Клименко А. Ф. Россия и Китай в системе безопасности Северо-Восточной Азии/ А. Ф. Клименко // Международные отношения КНР. 2014. №5. С. 31-50

5 Баранов И.Т. Китай в современном мире: экономика, политика, культура. М.: Издательство «Восток-Запад», 2020. С 256

1.2 The Essence of the «One Belt, One Road» Initiative

China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative is a development strategy comprising both the Silk Road Economic Belt and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road. It aims to expand economic cooperation among participating countries and facilitate the flow of all types of resources. President Xi Jinping first announced the «Silk Road Economic Belt» initiative in September 2013 in Astana, Kazakhstan, included most Eurasian countries within its framework and announced the start of cooperation. The international market is important for China's manufacturing industry. Foreign trade turnover reached USD 3.4 trillion in 2012, making China the world's largest exporter and second-largest importer. China has also become one of the world leaders in attracting foreign capital and in outward capital flows. In 2016, China received USD 139 billion in foreign direct investment, ranking second in the world. On 28 March 2015, China's National Development and Reform Commission (NDRC) published a strategic document setting out the goals and vision for jointly building the Silk Road Economic Belt and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road. The document sets out the main principles of cooperation within the initiative. China holds the world's largest foreign exchange reserves, and on 1 October 2016 the IMF granted the Chinese yuan reserve currency status. The Silk Road Economic Belt initiative should therefore be seen as a key factor in China's current economic development and future growth. First, the initiative will help China secure energy supplies in the long term; its aim is to ensure reliability. The 13th Five-Year Plan for Economic and Social Development (2016–2020), approved in 2016, emphasises the importance of strengthening cooperation in energy resources and production. Second, by 2030 the global middle class is expected to reach 4.9 billion people. These preconditions, real economic needs and the current balance of power in international relations created the conditions for launching the Silk Road Economic Belt initiative. Two years after China launched the

initiative, the document «Vision and Actions on Jointly Building the Silk Road Economic Belt and 21st Century Maritime Silk Road» was presented at the Boao Forum. [6789]

1.3 Main Areas of Cooperation

The initiative also envisaged the development of economic cooperation with neighbouring countries on the basis of connectivity, through the construction of a total of six land corridors. The aim of the «One Belt, One Road» initiative is to connect Asia, Europe and Africa along five routes.

The Silk Road Economic Belt aims at:

1. 1. Connecting China with Europe through Central Asia and Russia
2. Connecting China with the Middle East through Central Asia
3. Connecting China with Southeast Asia, South Asia and the Indian Ocean. The 21st Century Maritime Silk Road connects China's coastal ports.
4. Connecting China with Europe through the East China Sea and inland waters
5. Connecting China with the South Pacific through the South China Sea

If the five routes above are developed successfully, «One Belt, One Road» will create advantages in international transport, connect major cities and ports, and make it possible to form six international economic cooperation corridors.

1. New Eurasian Land Bridge

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6 The report from the United Nations conference on trade and development (unctad) shows that China is bucking the trend by attracting foreign investment URL: http://paper.people.com.cn/mrb/html/2017-02/03/nw.D110000renmrb_20170203_2-03.htm (дата обращения 09.03.2025)

7 Outline of the 13th five-year plan for national economic and social development of the People's Republic of China URL: http://news.xinhuanet.com/politics/2016lh/2016-03/17/c_1118366322.htm (дата обращения 06.04.2025)

8 Статьи о развитии инициативы «Один пояс, один путь» на сайте «Жэньминь Жибао» (электронный ресурс) Русский язык--People's Daily Online URL: О нас--People's Daily Online (дата обращения 21.02.2025)

9 One Belt And One Road "programming URL: http://language.chinadaily.com.cn/2015-03/30/content_19950951.htm (дата обращения 02.05.2025)

2. China–Mongolia–Russia

3. China–Central Asia–West Asia

4. China–Indochina Peninsula

5. China–Pakistan

6. Bangladesh–China–India–Myanmar

The New Eurasian Land Bridge is an international railway line that passes through Alashankou in Xinjiang and reaches Rotterdam in the Netherlands. The Chinese section includes the Lanzhou–Lianyungang and Lanzhou–Xinjiang railways, which cross eastern, central and western China. Beyond China, the line passes through Kazakhstan, Russia, Belarus and Poland and reaches many of Europe's coastal ports.

Using the New Eurasian Land Bridge, international freight railways connect Chongqing (China) with Duisburg (Germany), Wuhan with Mělník and Pardubice (Czech Republic), Chengdu with Łódź (Poland), and Zhengzhou with Hamburg (Germany). All these new routes allow transfer from one rail system to another, and the principle of «one declaration, one inspection, one release» applies to all cargo.

China–Mongolia–Russia Economic Corridor

China, Mongolia and Russia have a long history of economic cooperation linked by overland routes. In September 2014, the leaders of the three countries met for the first time in a trilateral format at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) summit in Dushanbe and discussed trilateral cooperation based on the bilateral relations between China and Russia, China and Mongolia, and Russia and Mongolia. This meeting set out in principle the direction and main areas of trilateral cooperation. The three leaders agreed to link China's Silk Road Economic Belt, Russia's modernised Eurasian land bridge (the Trans-Siberian Railway) and Mongolia's Steppe Road. This includes strengthening and building rail and road links and improving customs control and transport capacity, which will raise throughput and increase transit traffic in order to create the China–Mongolia–Russia economic corridor. In July 2015, the three heads of state held a second meeting in

Ufa, Russia, where they approved the Medium-Term Roadmap for the Development of Trilateral Cooperation between China, Russia and Mongolia.

The China–Central Asia–West Asia Economic Corridor runs from the Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region through Alashankou, leaving China and entering the Central Asia–West Asia railway corridor, and then reaches the Mediterranean and the Arabian Peninsula. The corridor covers five Central Asian countries (Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan) as well as Iran and Turkey in West Asia. At the third China–Central Asia Cooperation Forum, held in Shandong in June 2015, China committed to building the Silk Road Economic Belt, and five countries of the region signed a joint declaration. The Central Asian region is an integral element of Russia's Greater Eurasian Partnership concept and of the Chinese initiative, and it is also the core of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation. Coordination between Moscow and Beijing, and between them and the Central Asian states of Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Turkmenistan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan, can therefore improve regional connectivity and deepen trade and economic cooperation. A lack of coordination, in turn, could turn Central Asia into a zone of competition between great powers and other international actors and hinder the achievement of common and indivisible security in the region. In connection with the Silk Road Economic Belt, national development strategies were adopted: «Nurly Zhol» (Bright Path) in Kazakhstan, «Energy, Transport, Food» in Tajikistan, and «The Era of Power and Prosperity» in Turkmenistan.[10]

China–Indochina Peninsula Economic Corridor

At the fifth summit on regional economic cooperation held in Bangkok in December 2014, China and the five countries of the Indochina Peninsula put forward three initiatives to deepen cooperation: first, to build highways together; second, to develop a new financing model; and third, to improve social and economic indicators.

China–Pakistan Economic Corridor

10 «Российско-китайский диалог: модель 2024 - РСМД : Российско-китайский диалог: модель 2024

The concept of the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor was first proposed by Premier Li Keqiang during his visit to Pakistan in May 2013. The aim was to link Kashgar in Xinjiang in the north with the port of Gwadar in Pakistan. The two governments have since drawn up a long-term plan to build a highway, a railway, oil and gas pipelines and fibre-optic cables from Kashgar to Gwadar. In April 2015, a joint statement by China and Pakistan in Islamabad announced agreement on the second phase of the Karakoram Highway upgrade (Thakot–Havelian section), a new international airport, a railway line in Lahore, economic zones and other projects of the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor, and noted active progress in joint efforts to build an international fibre-optic network.

Bangladesh–China–India–Myanmar Economic Corridor

During Premier Li Keqiang's visit to India in May 2013, the creation of a Bangladesh–China–India–Myanmar economic corridor was discussed. The first meeting of the working group took place in Kunming in December 2013, where representatives of the four countries discussed the development of the corridor and reached common understanding on transport infrastructure, investment, trade flows and people-to-people cooperation. The «One Belt, One Road» initiative pursues five main goals: policy coordination, infrastructure connectivity, unimpeded trade, financial integration and people-to-people bonds. The Silk Road Fund, with capital of USD 40 billion, was established to finance the initiative and invest in financial cooperation projects. It was created in December 2014 as a limited liability company whose shares are held by the China Investment Corporation, the Export-Import Bank of China and the China Development Bank. It cooperates with other institutions such as the China–Africa Development Fund and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, alongside domestic investors. The Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) was established to finance infrastructure projects in energy, transport, communications, rural infrastructure, water supply, the environment and logistics. As of December 2015, 57 founding members had signed the cooperation agreement. China is currently the main producer of material goods, while Western European countries are their main consumers; trade between the PRC and

the EU is among the largest in the world and grows significantly every year. This trend makes it necessary to find additional infrastructure capacity to increase the flow of goods from China to the EU while reducing transport and logistics costs. At present, most cargo between China, India and other Asian countries is carried by sea: ships leave China, pass through the Strait of Malacca, the Indian Ocean and the Suez Canal, and then sail past Spain and France to the main European ports of Rotterdam and Hamburg. This logistics scheme is complicated by the fact that European seaports are not designed to receive larger numbers of large Chinese container ships. The implementation of the Belt and Road project therefore also serves to increase the volume of goods reaching European markets. Another reason for proposing the Silk Road Economic Belt relates to the «New Silk Road» policy announced by US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton in July 2011. That initiative was intended to play a key role in preserving US interests in the region after the withdrawal of troops from Afghanistan. Its southern direction focused on Afghanistan and aimed to connect Turkmenistan with the Indian subcontinent through Afghanistan and Pakistan by railways, highways and energy infrastructure, while its northern direction aimed to connect the Baltic and Caspian ports with Afghanistan through Russia, Central Asia and the Caucasus. The United States sought to use the «New Silk Road» as leverage to promote trade and investment and to spread Western democratic values such as civil society, the rule of law and human rights. For this reason, between 2010 and 2012 the United States provided USD 520 million in military support to Central Asian states to combat terrorism and drug trafficking, and USD 380 million in development aid. However, Iran, one of the largest countries in the region, remained outside this policy, and the policy clearly conflicted with Russia's interests. The «New Silk Road» also received little domestic support, as it was not economically advantageous for the United States. The Silk Road Economic Belt, by contrast, serves the interests not only of China but also

of Russia, as it creates an opportunity to move away from a unipolar world and reduce US influence in the Eurasian region. [11]

Chapter 2. Implementation of the «One Belt, One Road» Project

2.1 Implementation of the «Silk Road Economic Belt» Initiative in Central Asia

China is currently the largest trading partner of Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan and the second-largest partner of Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan. In 2014, China's trade with Central Asian countries amounted to USD 45 billion. The energy sector plays a leading role in China–Central Asia economic relations, and cooperation in infrastructure is also expanding rapidly. Since the launch of the Silk Road Economic Belt, ties in this area have become increasingly active. The Republic of Kazakhstan is one of the countries that participates most actively in the «One Belt, One Road» initiative and benefits from it. In 2014, Kazakhstan and China signed a cooperation plan to connect their infrastructure and build the Silk Road Economic Belt together with the «Nurly Zhol» (Bright Path) programme. China and Kazakhstan agreed to implement 52 joint projects with total investment of USD 24 billion. In December 2015, China's Silk Road Fund made its first investment, in a special fund for China–Kazakhstan industrial cooperation. Kazakhstan's budget allocated USD 9 billion to the «Nurly Zhol» programme over three years. The programme will build infrastructure along a northern route (the Western Europe–Western China highway), a central route (the China–Kazakhstan–Azerbaijan–Georgia–Turkey railway) and a southern route (the Kazakhstan–Turkmenistan–Iran railway). The northern

11 Пименова А. О. «Один пояс – один путь» как глобальный экономический проект Китая // Концепт. – 2020. – № 5. – С. 209-215.

and central highways and railways are directly linked to China's «One Belt, One Road» project. The northern highway begins in St Petersburg and connects China and Russia; its length is 8,445 km, of which 2,787 km run through Kazakhstan. The central route links two separate railways: the line from the Chinese border at Khorgos to the Kazakh port of Aktau will be connected with the Baku–Tbilisi–Kars railway. Since February 2015, a China–Kazakhstan train has run from the port of Lianyungang in eastern China to Almaty. With this service, Kazakhstan became the first country in Central Asia to gain a rail connection to a Pacific port without transhipment. Tajikistan: a 48.6-km railway connecting central and southern Tajikistan was built by China Railway 19th Bureau Group and opened in August 2016, at a total cost of USD 72 million. Uzbekistan: the longest tunnel in Central Asia, the 19.2-km Kamchik tunnel, was built jointly by Chinese and Uzbek companies and opened in June 2016. It has become an important part of the China–Central Asia–Europe international transport corridor. The total project cost was USD 1.6 billion, financed by the Fund for Reconstruction and Development of Uzbekistan, Uzbekistan Railways and international financial institutions; the Export-Import Bank of China provided USD 350 million. Kyrgyzstan has a population of more than 5 million, a GDP of USD 6 billion, poor infrastructure and an economy based on mining. The main route of China's Silk Road Economic Belt also passes through Kyrgyzstan.[12][13][14][15][16]

China–Kyrgyzstan–Uzbekistan trilateral highway:

The project was initiated by Uzbekistan in 1997 to gain access to China through Kyrgyzstan, and the three countries signed a memorandum of understanding. In 1999, the Chinese side studied and presented designs for southern and northern routes through

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12 Expert: "One Belt, One Road" has injected new viality into the economy and trade Cooperation between China and Central Asia

13 The first special fund for china-kazakhstan production capacity cooperation was established with the silk round fund of us $2 billion URL: http://news.xinhuanet.com/fortune/2015-12/14/c_1117457062.htm (дата обращения 22.04.2025)

14 The Central Asian Railway Express (Lianyungang - Almaty) was successfully launched from china-Kazakhstan Lianyungang International Logistics Base URL:http://www.lygsqgj.com/content/?86.html (дата обращения 08.05.2025)

15 The opening ceremony of the first vaya railway in tajikstan was held with the participation of Chinese enterprises URL:http://www.world.people.com.cn/n1/2016-08/31/c_1119486765.htm (дата обращения 07.05.2025)

16 A documentary on the Silk Road Economic Belt jointly built by China and Central Asia URL: http://news.xinhuanet.com/world/2016-08/31/c_1119486765.htm (дата обращения 04.04.2025)

Kyrgyz territory. The Uzbek government approved them immediately, but the Kyrgyz side repeatedly postponed the project because of financial and technical problems related to standards. Nevertheless, partial construction of the 959-km highway through the three countries has begun. A Chinese company built a 40.2-km road from Osh (Kyrgyzstan) to the Chinese border, which was completed and opened in 2005. Kyrgyzstan raised funds for the road through a «resources-for-infrastructure» arrangement with China: the Chinese company Zijin Mining Group, through its subsidiary, acquired a 60 percent stake and shareholder loans in a gold mine in Kyrgyzstan, and the Kyrgyz side received USD 660 million from the transfer of these shareholder rights and loans. [17][18]

China–Kyrgyzstan–Uzbekistan trilateral railway:

The total length of railways in Kyrgyzstan is 350 km. Of these, 300 km run from the border with Kazakhstan to the mining area along Kyrgyzstan's northern border (the northern route), and the remaining 50 km run along the southern route from Uzbekistan into the Jalal-Abad region of Kyrgyzstan. Both railways lie in border zones and do not connect. Twenty years ago, Kyrgyzstan planned to build a single national rail network of «one vertical and two horizontal» lines, but it has still not been built. The southern of the two horizontal lines was to become a trilateral China–Kyrgyzstan–Uzbekistan transport route (total length 476 km). This railway is of strategic importance, linking China, Central Asia, West Asia, North Africa and Southern Europe. In 1997, the governments of China, Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan signed a memorandum of understanding on building the trilateral railway. However, construction costs and the difficulty of raising funds have so far kept it a «dream». The initial cost estimate of USD 900 million rose to USD 1.3 billion after several years, to USD 2 billion in 2006, USD 4.5 billion in 2012 and USD 6.5 billion in 2013, which provoked public anger and opposition. International lenders are reluctant to support Kyrgyzstan financially because of its weak economy and high external debt. At

17 The china-djibouti railway is easier said than built
URL: http://blog.sina.com.cn/s/blog_a6ca22020101oqun.html (дата обращения 015.04.2025)

18 Zijin mining group co., LTD. On the acquisition of kyrgyz left bank gold mine announcement
URL: http://www.cninfo.com.cn/finalpage/2011-08-17/59827658.PDF (дата обращения 02.05.2025)

present, Kyrgyzstan has two ways of raising funds. One is to obtain a long-term loan from China, but this would triple Kyrgyzstan's external debt. The other is to raise money by developing mineral deposits, but this faces strong public opposition, as many regard it as a waste of resources. After A. Atambayev was elected President, the government programme for 2013–2017 included 16 infrastructure projects worth USD 2.1 billion, of which USD 1.5 billion was earmarked for railways and the rest for highways, but the funding question remains unresolved. In 2012, the governments of China and Kyrgyzstan signed another memorandum of understanding on the trilateral railway, and in April 2013 the Chinese side presented a feasibility study, which Kyrgyzstan accepted. However, in May 2013 Kyrgyzstan welcomed Russia's proposal to build a Russia–Kazakhstan–Kyrgyzstan–Tajikistan railway. Chinese researchers also believe that China's participation in the Kyrgyz railway could affect Russian interests, and that it would therefore be advisable to cooperate, including by involving Russia in the project. The example of Uzbekistan shows that a trilateral approach to financing, involving the host country, international financial institutions and China, is also valuable experience.[19][20]

2.2 Cooperation and Interaction of the PRC with Countries Participating in the «One Belt, One Road» Project

Another factor that may affect the implementation of the trilateral economic corridor and its coherence is the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU) and the projects implemented

19 Liao chengmei and wang caixia : analysis of the reasons restricting the construction of sino-jian-uzbekstan railway URL: http://pit.ifeng.com/a/20160701/49276891_0.shtml (дата обращения 08.05.2025)

20 The commentary said it was Russia that disrupted the china-djibouti railway URL:http://finance.sina.com.cn/review/sbzt/20140310/145918461249.shtml (дата обращения 07.05.2025)

within it. The Union is an economic association covering most of the territory of the former Soviet Union, formed under Russia's leading influence in the regions neighbouring Mongolia. The Treaty on the Eurasian Economic Union was signed on 29 May 2014 and entered into force on 1 January 2015. It was built on the Customs Union established on 1 January 2010 by the Russian Federation, the Republic of Belarus and the Republic of Kazakhstan. The Republic of Armenia joined on 2 January 2015 and the Kyrgyz Republic on 12 August 2015. The total population of the member states is 182.7 million (2.5 percent of the world population), and their combined GDP is USD 2.2 trillion. The goals of the EAEU are to ensure sustainable economic development in order to raise living standards in member states; to create a single market for goods, services, capital and labour within the Union; and to modernise, integrate and increase the competitiveness of member economies in line with current global economic trends. The highest governing body of the EAEU is the Supreme Council, composed of the heads of member states, which meets at least once a year. The permanent working body of the Union is the Eurasian Economic Commission. Member states chair EAEU bodies in rotation; in 2016 this role was held by the Republic of Kazakhstan. The Eurasian Development Bank was established in 2006 by Russia and Kazakhstan. Its head office is in Almaty, with branches in St Petersburg, Bishkek, Dushanbe, Yerevan, Minsk and Moscow. The main goal of the EAEU is to abolish customs duties in trade between member states, create a single customs territory and then introduce a common tariff towards third countries. This goal has not yet been fully achieved, particularly for goods such as petroleum products, natural gas, energy, alcohol and automobiles. A common electricity market is expected by 2019, and common oil and gas markets by 2025. Projects of mutual interest are implemented jointly within the EAEU. As of 1 October 2016, the investment portfolio of the Eurasian Development Bank amounted to USD 2.081 billion across 58 projects; 28.72 percent of these are in the energy sector and 19.03 percent in transport. To date, 31 projects have been completed or are under way, including: industrial development of the Voskhod chromite deposit; industrial uranium mining at the Zarechnoye deposit (Kazakhstan); construction of the

Northern Kazakhstan–Aktobe power line; financing of the Sukhoi Superjet 100 aircraft; construction of a railcar plant in Tikhvin; financing of the purchase and production of heavy mining equipment; financing of agro-industrial complexes in member states; production of modern railway tank containers and freight wagons (Belarus); technical modernisation of Ekibastuz GRES-2; financing of the Elga coal deposit (Russia); financing of the Bogatyr Komir coal mine; construction of a hydropower plant on the Western Dvina; financing of the railway sector in Kazakhstan; financing of a gold mining project in Kazakhstan; construction of hotel complexes in Kazakhstan and Belarus; the Western High-Speed Diameter motorway in St Petersburg; financing of the Beloporozhskaya HPP-1 and HPP-2; financing of the Sakhalin GRES-2 project; reconstruction of the Magadan seaport; and projects for building and equipping naval vessels (Kazakhstan). Among EAEU countries, Kazakhstan is the most active participant in these projects, followed by Russia. Under the Silk Road Economic Belt, goods from China will be able to reach Europe by rail in 14–18 days, and the corridor through Kazakhstan is becoming dominant. Another potential joint railway project is a high-speed line from China to Europe through Russia. For example, the Chinese side agreed to invest in the Moscow–Kazan high-speed railway, financing one third of its total cost, with Russian Railways (RZD) participating on the Russian side. During Li Keqiang's visit to Russia in November 2016, a memorandum of understanding defining the route of the high-speed railway was signed. In other modes of transport, such as road transport, Russia's participation remains small: only 3.5 percent of Russia's total exports are carried by road, owing to the poor quality of Russian roads, low capacity and high maintenance costs. Although EAEU projects are not directly linked to the trilateral economic corridor, they are linked indirectly through Russia's participation. Exports of energy resources such as coal and the growth of freight traffic on the Trans-Siberian Railway will clearly have a direct impact on the implementation of the corridor.

The western branch of the Northern Corridor of the Silk Road Economic Belt relates to the Mongolia–Russia–China trilateral economic corridor. The functioning of this corridor

is shaped by geographical, economic, political and historical factors. First, Mongolia's territory, a rectangle roughly 2,400 km wide and 1,260 km high lying directly between Russia and China, is of only regional importance when bypassed from the east, while a route around it to the west must cross the high Altai Mountains, making any roads, pipelines or lines very costly to build. The shortest transit route between Asia and Europe therefore passes through Mongolia. For example, the distance from the Yellow Sea coast to Yekaterinburg is about 6,000 km through Mongolia, 6,700 km through Manchuria and 6,500 km through Kazakhstan. Second, the trade route connecting the three countries through Kalgan (Zhangjiakou), Urga (Ulaanbaatar) and Kyakhta has a history of more than a century and became known as the Tea Road; in the mid-20th century, rail transport was added to this route. Third, every corridor aims to strengthen its sponsors' influence in the region, create a single political and economic space and prevent other countries from gaining control over it. For the two neighbouring countries, the project has a dual purpose: to limit the influence of third countries in Mongolia, and to prevent the corridor from being penetrated by flows of refugees and migrants fleeing extremism and terrorism, and by drug trafficking. The China–Mongolia–Russia corridor is therefore one of the most promising routes within the «One Belt, One Road» initiative. A further advantage is that additional capital investment is likely to be relatively small, since rail and road networks already exist. According to some Chinese research organisations, the northern corridor is considered the most promising of the routes to Europe for the following reasons:

- The shortest route from Northeast Asia to Europe passes through Mongolia.
- China's economic centre of gravity is concentrated around Beijing, Hebei and Henan, which are the closest regions to Mongolia's railway. A route through Mongolia would therefore make it possible, at low cost, to connect China's industrial provinces with Russia's resource-rich regions.
- Importing base metals such as copper, iron, molybdenum, tungsten and zinc, as well as energy such as coal, oil and electricity, from Mongolian deposits located near the border will clearly be cheaper for China.

- As countries industrialise, they tend to move environmentally harmful industries, such as coal mining and thermal power plants, to neighbouring regions. The vast and sparsely populated southern areas of Mongolia have comparatively high potential for cooperation with China in this respect. The advantages of the trilateral corridor over other corridors include fewer participating countries, lower transit costs, the shortest route (through Mongolia), a much calmer and more stable domestic situation in Mongolia and Russia than in Central and South Asia, a very low level of terrorism and a generally more stable investment environment. The need for the corridor is also driven by China's domestic economic conditions. China has excess manufacturing capacity: industrial capacity utilisation currently stands at 75 percent, whereas 82 percent is considered normal by international standards. China is therefore taking steps to move part of its production to other countries; in other words, it has begun relocating earlier-stage industries to neighbouring, less developed countries. China is closing many of its small coal-fired power plants and creating large clusters, and the discussion of a USD 10 billion investment project to build the Shivee-Ovoo power plant in Mongolia is an example of this process.[21]

2.3 Russia and the PRC in the Implementation of the Project

If goods from China to Europe are transported through Mongolia, traffic on the Trans-Siberian Railway will increase, as will transit fees on the Russian side and related services along the route, raising economic benefits. Since the Ulaanbaatar Railway is a Mongolian–Russian joint venture, higher traffic is also in Russia's interest and will increase its dividends.

Russia pursues a policy of preserving and, where possible, expanding its broad-gauge railway network. It is therefore interested in building new railways and increasing transit

21 Path, obstacle and strategy analysis of china-mongolia-russia economic corridor construction URL: http://ww.ite-china.com.cn/zhong-meng-e-jing-ji-zou-lang-jian-she-lu-jing-zhang-aiji-zhan-lue-fen-xi/ (дата обращения 08.05.2025)

traffic through Mongolia, which will in turn create conditions for greater traffic on the Ulaanbaatar Railway. China's «21st Century Silk Road» initiative consists of two parts: the overland Silk Road and the Maritime Silk Road. It aims to connect China's transport infrastructure with that of the countries in the region, reduce transport costs and transit times, bring border-control standards closer together and eventually unify them, and create conditions that allow other countries to carry out single-window inspections. According to preliminary estimates, the initiative will at least halve transport times and transport costs. China plans to create six transport and economic corridors, one of which will pass through Mongolia: the economic corridor for Russia, Mongolia and China. Russia plays an important role in China's «Going Out» policy. The two countries reached a strategic agreement at head-of-state level on supplying China with the energy resources it lacks and including Russia in its supply chain. They agreed that Russia would borrow from China the funds needed to bring some of its largest deposits into production and repay the loans with output from those deposits. For example, a contract to build a gas pipeline was signed, and China provided a USD 25 billion loan for the project, which was a major breakthrough for Russia's economic development. As Russia sought to offset the sanctions and reduced cooperation imposed by Western countries after the events in Crimea in 2014, it compensated through closer cooperation with China in the east. In 2006, during President Vladimir Putin's visit to Beijing, a memorandum of understanding on oil and gas supplies to China was signed, after which China began investing actively in the Russian oil and gas sector. For China and other countries, the depreciation of the rouble in recent years has significantly affected investment in Russia. Chinese investment in the Russian economy has grown steadily, reaching USD 1 billion in 2014. While Central Asian countries are rich in the raw materials China needs, China has financial resources, relatively inexpensive technologies and an abundance of consumer goods. The Chinese Premier's first visit to Central Asia in 1994 laid the foundation for friendly relations and cooperation, after which high-level visits intensified and trade and economic cooperation expanded. In 2009 and 2010, pipelines carrying oil and natural gas from Central Asia to

China came into operation, enabling China to import oil from Kazakhstan and gas from Turkmenistan. Agreements were signed to purchase natural gas and metals from Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan. As a result, trade grew rapidly, from USD 1 billion in 2000 to USD 30 billion in 2012. The parties signed long-term cooperation documents under which China finances major projects: for example, in 2013 China and Kazakhstan signed energy agreements worth USD 30 billion, and in 2006 China and Turkmenistan signed energy agreements worth USD 7.31 billion. In infrastructure, China agreed to invest in major projects such as the Chongqing–Xinjiang–Europe international railway connecting Central Asia and Europe, a Europe–China high-speed railway, a Moscow–Beijing highway, the Kashgar (Xinjiang)–Irkeshtam (Kyrgyzstan) highway and the upgrading of the Western China–Russia–Central Asia highway. Chinese authorities have stated that they aim to increase trade with ASEAN to USD 400 billion and to USD 1 trillion by 2020. During his visit to India in 2014, Xi Jinping announced possible investment of USD 20 billion in the country's infrastructure and industry. After sanctions on Iran were lifted in early 2016, President Xi Jinping paid an official visit to Iran, during which the two countries agreed on a 25-year comprehensive strategic partnership aimed in particular at developing the energy sector. During the same Middle East tour, the Chinese President also visited Saudi Arabia and Egypt, where the parties decided to raise cooperation to a strategic level and to expand interaction in the energy sector.

Chapter 3. Problems and Prospects of the «One Belt, One Road» Project

3.1 Problems and Challenges of the «One Belt, One Road» Initiative

The objectives of China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative include creating regional value chains, relocating economically inefficient and environmentally harmful industries abroad, supporting the development of the north-western provinces and increasing the sales of Chinese construction companies. A secondary aim is to increase cargo transit, diversifying the risks of maritime shipping caused by an unfavourable political situation at sea, in addition to offering cheaper overland transport. The Silk Road will become a channel for exporting Chinese production capacity, and through international cooperation regional producers will be able to use Chinese equipment and investment rather than join the production networks of Chinese companies. New industrial clusters are planned in the regions covered by the initiative, and the Chinese authorities plan to build training centres alongside Chinese companies. The Chinese government has drawn up a three-year action plan for international cooperation and decided to invest heavily in megaprojects along the Silk Road. International cooperation under the initiative is an important part of the People's Republic of China's 13th Five-Year Plan. In addition to exporting surplus industrial output, China plans to export Chinese standards, technologies and brands. A transport route connecting Europe and China will promote foreign trade, economic growth and regional cooperation. Infrastructure development between states will form the basis of cooperation with members of the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS), which are ready to cooperate within the initiative and benefit from joining the Eurasian transport and logistics network. Projects implemented under the initiative will promote foreign trade with neighbouring countries and the creation of new economic and industrial clusters.

3.2 Implementation of the Chinese «Silk Road» Project

China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative should not be understood merely as a set of projects to build an entirely new transport system and infrastructure around the world. It should instead be seen as China's attempt to exercise soft power through the Silk Road and to ensure its diversified development. To implement the initiative, Beijing plans and carries out many projects in cooperation with developing countries. In the long term, China's involvement in Central Asian affairs is therefore likely to grow and to become the first major driver of economic development in the region since the socialist era. According to China's Ministry of Commerce, by April 2017 China had signed agreements with the government of Kazakhstan worth a total of USD 304.9 million since the launch of the overland Silk Road Economic Belt in 2013. For the initiative to succeed, China needs to support the sectors that can supply the most goods to China, optimise the structure of its foreign trade and spread risks. Dependence on China for goods and investment exposes partner economies to risk; for Central Asian countries, the greatest risk is dependence on trade with China. Turkmenistan, for example, now depends on China as the sole buyer of its gas since Russia stopped purchasing Turkmen natural gas in 2016. The successful implementation of the Silk Road Economic Belt has two sides. On the one hand, Central Asian countries will increase their exports and achieve economic stability. On the other, China's Xinjiang province is developing its own mining, energy, food and light industries, creating a risk of direct competition with key sectors of the Central Asian economies; in other words, Central Asian countries must compete with the Xinjiang Uygur Autonomous Region for export markets in eastern China. China's initiative aims to secure its natural resources and energy supplies. China seeks to address its military, political and cultural challenges by strengthening its regional and global influence. The project envisages initiatives that begin in China, extend to the region and eventually reach all parts of the

world. By creating such west–east economic corridors, China will strengthen its political, economic, military and soft-power positions and achieve its many goals. Chinese assistance should be seen as a combination of concessional loans and foreign direct investment intended to support sustainable development. This financing may give the lender rights to develop the recipient country's natural resources or lead to comprehensive intergovernmental agreements. In this respect, Chinese assistance differs in content and principle from Western loans. Chinese assistance is delivered as a package that includes loan financing, aid, trade agreements and investment agreements, and receiving it implies meeting certain requirements set by China. Loan conditions are often closely tied to the interests of Chinese companies: countries receiving concessional loans for infrastructure projects must purchase at least half of the goods, equipment, technology and services under the agreement from Chinese companies, and the participation of Chinese companies is another condition of concessional lending. This is likely to lead Chinese state-owned companies to expand abroad, win foreign contracts and acquire resources, allowing them to compete with Western companies that dominate foreign markets. In 2006, China granted Kyrgyzstan a concessional loan of USD 1.2 billion to build a railway in exchange for mining licences and permits. In 2009, China provided Turkmenistan with a USD 4 billion loan and obtained permission to explore and develop the largest natural gas field in South Yolotan, near the Afghan border. A key issue facing the initiative is the level of external debt of borrowing countries. The risk of default in developing countries with unstable economies has been rising in recent years. Of the 68 countries China cooperates with, 23 have low credit ratings, and eight of these carry the highest credit risk: Djibouti, Kyrgyzstan, Laos, the Maldives, Mongolia, Pakistan, Tajikistan and Montenegro. If these countries borrow from China, their public debt is expected to reach 50 percent of GDP by the end of 2030; in Djibouti, Mongolia and Montenegro the public debt ratio would exceed 80 percent, and in the Maldives it would reach 109 percent. Interest rates on Chinese investment loans vary: in Pakistan they are practically interest-free, while in Djibouti they are at the level of commercial loans. Because repayments often extend over decades, these

countries risk default during that period. Chinese assistance is based on the principle of avoiding losses under any circumstances and always reflects China's national interests. Some countries describe Chinese assistance as «exploitative», because under loan agreements the borrowing country, in addition to repaying principal and interest, may be required to make economic or political concessions in line with the interests of the lender or its affiliated companies. Although Chinese financing increases trade and stimulates economic activity in Central Asia, countries in the region risk becoming dependent on Chinese investment to maintain the stability and development of the infrastructure built under the initiative. As trade grows, the comparative advantage of Chinese companies will increase, reducing the competitiveness of firms in borrowing countries and raising Central Asian demand for imports from China. Today China is interested in importing raw materials, energy and mining products from Central Asia and exporting finished goods to it. One manifestation of the initiative is therefore what critics call China's «exploitative lending». Although «One Belt, One Road» is a multilateral cooperation project, it also aims to strengthen China's economic and political dominance. Tajikistan has already accepted Chinese investment and expansion strategies, and Chinese investment is flowing actively into all sectors of its economy, especially construction and urban development. Kyrgyzstan is negotiating with China to conclude more mutually beneficial agreements and attract more investment, but at the same time pursues a policy of limiting the intensity of foreign investment. Kyrgyzstan's democratic politics and its membership of the Eurasian Economic Union are distinctive in how they have shaped Chinese investment flows. Under the initiative, Kazakhstan is expected to develop its transport infrastructure, increase transit revenues and attract more Chinese direct investment. In May 2016, Kazakhstan's Minister of Agriculture Gulmira Isayeva stated that negotiations were under way to finance 19 agricultural projects worth USD 1.9 billion under the initiative, and that Chinese companies would not have the right to own land in Kazakhstan. On 11 July 2017 in Astana, Kazakhstan and China signed seven agreements worth USD 160 million. A joint study by Nazarbayev University and J-Invest-Consulting surveyed 300 influential

representatives from Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan. Most participants (96 percent) considered Chinese investment beneficial, but 80 percent opposed immigration from China, followed by concerns about environmental pollution and ecological balance (70 percent). Between 30 and 40 percent believed that Chinese investment was likely to upset the geopolitical balance; 59 percent of Kazakh and 44 percent of Kyrgyz respondents believed that it had a negative effect on national security, and only 6 percent wished Chinese workers to remain in their country. Kyrgyzstan is more willing to cooperate with China than Kazakhstan: 65–75 percent of Kyrgyz participants supported a free trade agreement (compared with 35–50 percent of Kazakh participants for free trade in goods and capital), and 43 percent of Kyrgyz citizens support a visa-free regime, whereas 77 percent of Kazakh citizens oppose it. According to the researcher, Chinese investment practices do not meet ethical standards, and strong wariness towards China persists in the social and political life of the region. Although Kazakhstan aims to join the world's 30 most developed countries by 2050, the 2016 protests over land ownership clearly demonstrated anti-Chinese sentiment. Some citizens of the region believe that China's involvement in Central Asia may be the result of a hidden agenda. Some Central Asians believe that infrastructure projects built with Chinese support risk turning Central Asia into a source of raw materials and natural resources for China, while others think it may be an attempt to use the region to ease China's demographic pressure.

3.3 Development Prospects of the «One Belt, One Road» Megaproject

China's interest in Central Asia is not limited to economic motives; there is a strategic policy behind it. The main economic reason is the region's importance as a major exporter of oil and natural gas. Kazakhstan and Turkmenistan are important partners

because they can provide China with uninterrupted energy supplies, and cooperation with them allows China to ensure balanced economic development of its western and eastern provinces. A second reason is that China seeks to ease anti-Chinese sentiment in the region, since many Central Asian societies still feel anxiety about a «Chinese threat». The third reason is China's national security goal of combating terrorism, separatism and extremism. After the withdrawal of US and allied troops from Afghanistan, security threats emerged along China's western border, and China therefore needs to join forces with Central Asian countries to ensure regional stability and security. To pursue its goals, China uses a range of soft-power instruments. In addition to investment, these include educational programmes, scientific cooperation, cultural exchange and information cooperation. Knowledge of Chinese is becoming increasingly important, and its status among Central Asians is rising. As young people in Central Asia become more motivated to learn Chinese, the status of Russian is declining: the number of Russian speakers is falling while the prestige of Chinese grows. In language education, the principle «develop Chinese, maintain Russian and learn English» is being applied. As China invests actively in infrastructure and agricultural projects in Central Asia, it has become aware of growing anti-Chinese sentiment in the economic, business and socio-cultural environment. China has therefore begun a planned public diplomacy and a range of activities to improve its image in the region. China's soft-power policy aims to show that it is a competitive economic partner compared with the United States and Russia. To strengthen ties with Central Asian countries, President Xi Jinping decided to provide government scholarships to 30,000 students and to invite 10,000 teachers and students to China to become acquainted with Chinese culture. Education in China brings advantages: in the 2006–2007 academic year, 1,200 Kazakh students studied in China, and their number later rose to 11,200. Tourism is growing rapidly, with most Central Asian tourists travelling to Xinjiang; in 2017, 17 percent of all tourists visiting the region came from Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan. Within the initiative, the Chinese central government makes great efforts to promote the importance of the initiative. According

to the researcher, however, Chinese cultural institutions are not effective in creating a positive image of China, for several reasons: there are too few such institutions in the region, and there is little engagement with their graduates, so human capital is not used. Although these institutions aim to strengthen political and economic cooperation, their results in Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan have not been very positive. The centres are established by the government and are tightly regulated, and they appear to function more as instruments of publicity than as a means of building a positive image. Local residents protest against the arrival of large numbers of Chinese workers linked to Chinese investment. After the initiative was announced, anti-Chinese movements and protests increased sharply. There have been unrest and protests in Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan, and major protests in Kazakhstan over the allocation of land for agricultural use. Countries with small populations bordering China fear large-scale immigration. Central Asia has a total population of about 68 million, and the media increasingly amplify the idea of a «Chinese threat» because of the size of China's population. There is also a widespread view that immigrants increase competition in the local labour market and reduce the competitiveness of local workers. Other factors also sustain anti-Chinese sentiment in Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan, including political conflicts and propaganda by groups and parties that support anti-Chinese movements and exploit limited knowledge of Chinese culture, language and customs. These factors cause conflicts between citizens, especially between Chinese workers and local employers. Attitudes towards Chinese companies also remain negative, because they do not carry out corporate social responsibility activities or address the problems of local communities. For many Central Asians, anti-Chinese sentiment was formed during the Sino-Soviet conflict of the 1960s and 1970s and persists to this day. In Kazakhstan, projects implemented jointly with China are perceived differently by different social groups: while central government officials expand cooperation with China, the closer a project comes to public life, the environment and ordinary people, the more resistance it meets. The results of China's soft-power policy are therefore mixed and have not yet achieved

the desired effect. Although the initiative is useful for participating countries and offers significant future benefits, it still faces considerable cultural and social problems. On 22 August 2014, during President Xi Jinping's state visit to Mongolia, he presented the idea of «One Belt, One Road» at a special session of the Mongolian parliament: «China is ready to intensify cooperation with the Mongolian side within the Silk Road Economic Belt initiative. We take an active and open approach to the Steppe Road initiative proposed by the Mongolian side.» The Joint Declaration signed by the two heads of state also refers to cooperation within the economic belt initiative and to Mongolia's participation as a founding member of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank. The Steppe Road concept envisages building five links (roads, railways, oil and gas pipelines and power lines) connecting Asia and Europe through Mongolian territory. Then, on 3 September 2014, during a working visit to Mongolia, Russian President Vladimir Putin stated: «We are also well aware of the Silk Road project. It can be coordinated with other Russian projects. There is also the Steppe Road project; perhaps a power line could be built through Mongolian territory. This can be done if China and Mongolia are interested.» This confirmed high-level support from the neighbouring heads of state for the Silk Road and Steppe Road initiatives. Subsequently, on 11 September 2014, at the meeting of the three heads of state in Dushanbe, Tajikistan, President Ts. Elbegdorj of Mongolia proposed three main principles for the trilateral summit. First, the trilateral summit should be held every three years in Ulaanbaatar, with the deputy foreign ministers of the three countries meeting there annually to prepare it. Second, the summit should be open and consistent with the basic principles of trilateral cooperation. Third, the summit should address issues of interest to all three countries, such as transport, infrastructure and regional security. He added that Mongolia was interested in building a trilateral railway link and a Russia–China gas pipeline through western Mongolia, and proposed a working meeting in Ulaanbaatar to discuss these issues. President Putin, speaking of the tasks of trilateral relations, highlighted the construction of a new railway connecting Russia, Mongolia and China, the linking of the Silk Road and Steppe Road

projects with similar Russian projects, and the construction of a power line through Mongolia. In response, Xi Jinping noted that the development strategies of the three countries were highly compatible and proposed creating an economic zone along the Silk Road. The proposal was supported by Russia and Mongolia, with the emphasis that Russia's initiative to build the main Eurasian railway should be linked with Mongolia's Steppe Road, with the creation of an economic corridor involving China, Russia and Mongolia, and with a power grid connecting the three countries. The three heads of state met again to discuss the creation of the Mongolia–Russia–China economic corridor. To implement the memorandum on developing the programme for the corridor as quickly as possible, leading scholars and researchers from the three countries have worked together to develop a scientific basis for the medium-term cooperation roadmap and to raise trilateral cooperation to a new level. Joint research by scholars of the three countries has become a pressing task. For China, building «One Belt, One Road» is one of the most important goals of its development strategy. It is understood as an idea of mutually beneficial cooperation among countries across West, Central, East and Southeast Asia, Europe, East Africa and the Americas, based on the principles of joint consultation, joint construction and shared benefits, in which countries compensate for each other's weaknesses and build on their strengths. The Steppe Road project initiated by Mongolia envisages building a power line to Russia and a Eurasian high-speed railway. It is expected not only to bring benefits but also to stimulate economic cooperation among the countries of the Asia-Pacific region. If this is achieved, the Steppe Road project, which will connect Asia and Europe through five links (roads, railways, oil and gas pipelines, and power lines) across Mongolian territory, will be fully implemented. The Association of Think Tanks established by scholars of the three countries is expected to play an important role in preparing the feasibility study for the Mongolia–Russia–China economic corridor, proposed by President Ts. Elbegdorj at the second meeting of the three heads of state in Ufa, Russia, and in ensuring the coordination and coherence of the project. The Government of Mongolia's roadmap states: «We will create a transport

corridor connecting Russia, China, Asia and Europe and increase the volume of transit traffic through Mongolian territory.» To implement this provision, a main direction of Mongolia's economic and social development in 2014 was «to define and implement policies to create railway, road, oil, natural gas and energy infrastructure connecting Russia and China». The Government of Mongolia attaches great importance to expanding mutually beneficial, equal and balanced cooperation among the three countries, and President Ts. Elbegdorj's proposal to intensify trilateral cooperation and hold regular meetings of heads of state has begun to be implemented. It is also necessary to consider the current state of cooperation in trade, the economy and infrastructure between Mongolia, Russia and China. The original idea of the Steppe Road emerged when Mongolia joined the Asian Highway Network in April 2004 under an intergovernmental agreement among member states of the UN Economic and Social Commission for Asia and the Pacific (ESCAP). Accordingly, Mongolia is required to build the AH3, AH32 and AH4 highways on its territory. To fulfil this obligation, the Government of Mongolia's action plan for 2012–2016 set the goal of «creating a transport corridor connecting Russia, China, Asia and Europe and increasing transit traffic through Mongolian territory». The Chinggis Land Development group was selected through an international open tender to build the Altanbulag–Ulaanbaatar–Zamyn-Üüd expressway and on 16 March 2014 signed a concession agreement with the Ministry of Economic Development. Under the agreement, the company undertook to build more than 1,000 km of roads within two to three years using funds raised on international financial markets, and to transfer them to the state free of charge after 30 years. About 1,000 national and 30 foreign enterprises were expected to take part in the construction. By Government Resolution No. 283 of March 2008, the state-owned joint-stock company Mongolian Railway was established with 100 percent state ownership and received the right to build about 1,800 km of railway along the route Dalanzadgad–Sainshand–Khuut–Choibalsan–Ereentsav. The new railway is planned in order to connect mineral deposits, with funds raised on international financial markets. The

company signed contracts with private Mongolian companies to prepare 50 km of land in Dornod and Sükhbaatar provinces and 9 km in Sainshand, at a cost of USD 25 million, including earthworks and embankment construction. Thirty-five national companies took part in the project, of which 17 carried out geodetic surveys, 11 geological work and 4 detailed environmental assessments. The feasibility study for the new line was prepared by McKinsey, a US-based multinational consulting firm. In addition, the South Korean company Samsung completed earthworks on the 267-km Tavan Tolgoi–Gashuunsukhait line at a cost of USD 173 million. Although Mongolia lacks the financial capacity to build railways with its own funds and has little experience of raising capital on foreign markets, the government attaches great importance to exporting raw materials to Asia-Pacific markets by building the Dalanzadgad–Sainshand–Choibalsan line through the Sainshand industrial complex and connecting it with the mineral deposits of the eastern and central regions. This new railway is a very important geopolitical issue not only for Mongolia but for all three countries, and Mongolia must therefore first cooperate with its two neighbours and other countries and obtain financial and technical assistance from them. Mongolia's road and transport sector has played an important role in the social and economic development not only of Mongolia but also of Russia and China. Only two modes of transport are widespread in Mongolia, road and rail, and the importance of road transport is growing. This is explained, first, by the sharp fall in rail freight and the increase in road freight after the global economic crisis, and second, by increased government investment in building, maintaining and improving urban and local roads. Road transport therefore plays an important role in Mongolia's domestic and international freight. Of the 21.1 million tonnes of freight carried by rail in 2018, 50.1 percent was domestic, 10.8 percent imports, 29.3 percent exports and 9.8 percent transit. Compared with 2004, the share of domestic freight increased by 1.2 percentage points, imports by 2 points and exports by 21.3 points, while the share of transit freight through Mongolia fell by 24.5 points over the last ten years. By direction, freight from Russia to China accounts for the largest share. The existing railway cannot meet the transit needs

of Russia and China or the needs of Mongolia's economic and mining development. Experts believe that increasing transit volumes creates the following problems:[22][23]

1. There are no financial resources to double-track the Ulaanbaatar Railway;
2. The Ulaanbaatar Railway is very old and cannot accommodate heavy, high-speed trains;
3. The Sükhbaatar and Zamyn-Üüd border crossings have low capacity to handle large volumes of transit freight;
4. Mongolia, Russia and China are still negotiating on transit transport, but no concrete results have been achieved. To increase traffic through Mongolia, both Mongolia and Russia, as co-owners of the railway, face pressing tasks: increasing railway capacity, renewing the agreement on the Ulaanbaatar Railway signed in 1949, introducing modern railway technology, renewing rolling stock and building a new north–south double-track railway. In 2007, the Ulaanbaatar Railway joint-stock company, in cooperation with the Chinese railway authorities, prepared a feasibility study for a new north–south railway, but the project was not implemented because of financial problems and issues of joint ownership. At a time when the world energy market faces shortages of energy resources

22 Ежедневная Газета Монголии 2014.09.14 №219

23 Треугольник Россия, Монголия, Китай | Статья Марка Коулмена - опубликована в New Eastern Outlook.

24 Утверждено Постановлением № 37 Великого Государственного Хурала Монголии - Программа действий Правительства Монголии на 2012-2016 годы

25 Постановление № 39 Народного Собрания Монголии об утверждении основных направлений развития экономики и общества Монголии в 2014 году, 24 мая 2013 г.

26 План действий Правительства Монголии на 2012-2016 годы, утвержденный Постановлением № 37 Парламента Монголии

27 Об утверждении основных направлений развития экономики и общества Монголии в 2014 году-Постановление Верховного суда Республики Монголия № 39 от 24 мая 2013 г.

28 Соединяя Азию с Европой, начинается проект «Степная дорога». 26 августа 2014 г., URL: http://www.eagle.mn/content/ (дата обращения 03.05.2025)

29 Мы поговорили с Б. Батзайей на актуальные темы. 2012.03.11. http://www.mtz.mn/

30 Министерство дорог и транспорта, Заявление корпорации «Монгольские железные дороги», http://mrt.gov.mn/

31 Министерство дорог и транспорта Монголии, выпущено в декабре 2014 г. - Профиль железной дороги

and the global economic crisis is becoming more prolonged, countries are giving priority to intensifying regional cooperation, and Mongolia, Russia and China need to raise their comprehensive cooperation to a new level. Mongolia's two neighbours have begun to take measures to meet this need. For example, on 31 October 2007, the State Council of the PRC approved the «Medium- and Long-Term Railway Network Plan», which included expanding the rail network to 100,000–120,000 km and building five railway lines to Mongolia's southern border. Then, on 17 June 2008, the Government of the Russian Federation issued the «Strategy for the Development of Rail Transport until 2030». The strategy includes building 9,500 km of railways by 2015 and 10,900 km in 2015–2030, and increasing freight on the Trans-Siberian Railway by 100 million tonnes. It also provides for the repair and improvement of the Ulan-Ude–Naushki railway line. In addition, Russian Government Order No. 2094 of 28 December 2009 approved the Strategy for the Social and Economic Development of the Far East and the Baikal Region until 2025, which provides for RUB 346 billion from the federal budget in 2014–2025 to increase the capacity of transport corridors connecting Europe and Asia (the Trans-Siberian Railway, Primorye-1 and Primorye-2), including the modernisation of the Ulan-Ude–Kyakhta road towards Ulaanbaatar. A comparison of the strengths and weaknesses of the three countries, made to assess the conditions for creating the economic corridor, shows that their economic structures, capacities and market sizes differ, although all three are considered rich in natural resources. Mongolia has the advantages of a vast territory, rich agricultural resources, an open economy and environmentally clean traditional nomadic livestock farming. However, it also has weaknesses such as weak public administration, lack of access to the sea, a harsh climate, a relatively small market and underdeveloped processing industry and infrastructure. Russia and Mongolia are similar in lacking capital and financial resources and in depending on external markets. China is interested in implementing the Silk Road Economic Belt and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road together with Asian countries towards Europe, in order to strengthen its global influence and expand its markets. For Mongolia, within the Steppe Road project, the

interest in building a double-track Ulaanbaatar Railway, the Dalanzadgad–Sainshand–Khuut–Choibalsan–Ereentsav railway, a western north–south railway and the Altanbulag–Ulaanbaatar–Zamyn-Üüd expressway, connecting them with mineral deposits, processing raw materials at the Sainshand industrial complex and exporting them, coincides with the interests of its southern neighbour. Mongolia's central region, through which the Steppe Road passes, accounts for 78 percent of the country's GDP, 89 percent of its infrastructure, 76 percent of its fixed assets, 100 percent of its scientific and technical resources, 62.2 percent of its population, 75.3 percent of its industrial output, 64.9 percent of its agricultural land, 81.4 percent of its harvest, 23.8 percent of its livestock, 48.9 percent of its natural resources and 28.7 percent of its coal reserves. The central region of Mongolia therefore has relative advantages in social and economic resources, capacity, geographical location, climate and infrastructure compared with other regions, making it highly attractive for foreign and domestic investment.

It is believed that if Mongolia, Russia and China jointly create the economic corridor, it will have the following positive effects on the social and economic development of the three countries:

1. Mongolia will use its geographical advantages to become a trade, economic and infrastructure bridge between Russia and China, reducing the cost and time of transporting their goods through Mongolia;
2. Investment in the Mongolian economy will increase, large-scale construction will take place and thousands of new permanent and temporary jobs will be created;
3. Economic integration among the countries of Northeast Asia will strengthen, benefiting Mongolia, Russia and China;
4. Banking and financial infrastructure will be developed along the highway in Mongolia's central region, and clusters will be created in construction, urban development, transport and logistics, industry, services and tourism;
5. Mongolia's mineral deposits will be brought into economic use, leading to a sharp increase in gross domestic product and in real income per capita;

6. It will become possible to balance foreign trade between Russia and Mongolia and to restore traditional industrial and trade links between the two countries;
7. Mongolian national companies will have the opportunity to participate in major international megaprojects, learn best management practices and use modern methods and technologies. The creation of a trilateral economic corridor between Mongolia, Russia and China within «One Belt, One Road» therefore makes clear economic sense. How landlocked Mongolia participates in these megaprojects will determine the country's future prosperity, economic diversification, the living conditions of its people and, ultimately, the creation of a knowledge-based economy. The economic corridor will benefit all parties. However, since Mongolia has only two neighbours, Russia and China, the creation of the corridor must above all ensure equality and a balance of interests between both neighbouring countries.

Conclusion

As the world economy becomes increasingly globalised, the gap in national economic development is widening, and fewer countries reap the benefits of development. For large countries, foreign investment is a way to obtain the raw materials and products their economies need; for developing countries, it is a way to create financial opportunities by bringing their natural resources into economic use. In this situation, if countries do not design policies based on their national interests when receiving foreign investment, there is a danger that national wealth will pass into foreign hands without contributing to development and will ultimately be wasted. This situation has greatly facilitated the

implementation of China's initiative. The Chinese government's policy not only supplies the economy with the raw materials, metals and energy sources it needs, but also allows it to gain significant returns from overseas investment. It can be concluded that this policy has been implemented successfully and that China has become a major player on the world commodity market. China's cooperation with other countries, without political preconditions, and its financing of joint projects are producing tangible results. At the same time, the slowdown of China's economic growth has a certain negative effect on demand for, and prices of, the raw materials exported by developing countries. China's «One Belt, One Road» initiative is a major project for implementing China's policy of joint development and encourages participating countries and regions to take part in it. Its implementation will have a significant impact not only on regional development but also on the development of the Eurasian continent. International cooperation under the framework of «six corridors, six routes and multiple countries and ports» is steadily deepening, and projects such as the China–Europe Railway Express and the New International Land–Sea Trade Corridor have achieved concrete results. Belt and Road cooperation has created a total of 240,000 new jobs and generated USD 2 billion in tax revenue in the countries concerned. In other words, the initiative follows the trends of a new era and opens a new direction for international cooperation, and it is said to have given new momentum to global economic growth and created a new development platform for participating countries. However, the implementation of the initiative raises many economic problems. It should be emphasised that the infrastructure currently under construction is largely experimental, although in the long term such projects tend to prove successful. To develop long-term cooperation, participating countries need to pay attention to the environmental and social aspects of investment, and China needs to improve its image as the initiating country. There are concerns that Mongolia could come under the combined pressure of its two neighbours, but it is also doubtful that their core interests will always coincide on major issues. Both China and Russia have already launched strategic initiatives to expand their economic space on the Eurasian continent.

Although this effort to extend their influence will undoubtedly create competition in some areas, common interests appear to prevail. The trilateral programme can be seen as a sign that the two neighbouring countries accept and support Mongolia's new approach to foreign policy. In other words, conditions are being created to accelerate development by strengthening economic ties with neighbouring countries. In this historical period, as the centre of gravity of the world economy gradually shifts towards Eurasia, Mongolia has an opportunity to use the advantages of its geographical position. As for the challenges facing this Eurasian initiative, it will certainly meet resistance from large and influential competitors such as the United States, Japan and India. India, a strong economic and social competitor of China in the Asia-Pacific region, is seeking support from Japan and the United States for its Indo-Pacific initiative and the «Asia–Africa Growth Corridor», a maritime corridor connecting Africa and India through Southeast Asia. The United States, Japan and India have opposed the «One Belt, One Road» initiative, calling it «debt-trap diplomacy». Russia and China have historically been active partners in reducing US influence in Asia. The Russian daily Nezavisimaya Gazeta has nonetheless expressed concern that China's initiative could be a hidden policy of burdening Central Asian countries with debt. Kazakh researchers have also noted that citizens are dissatisfied with the large number of Chinese business people who have come to Central Asia as a result of the initiative. At the same time, China is paying increasing attention to its economic relations with India: since 2014, Chinese investment in India has reached about USD 8 billion. This suggests that China responds to external challenges by investing in economic cooperation. To overcome these challenges, it is important to show the world that joining «One Belt, One Road» offers equal development opportunities not only for China but also for the region and for less developed countries. As the ability of countries to develop on their own becomes increasingly limited, they increasingly need to join forces with their neighbours, regions and continents. Since excessive differences in development are disadvantageous for all countries, the initiative's principle of joint implementation and common development has rightly attracted the interest of many countries.

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